

whorl and stitch into a high-end confection, he knows how to look fabulous without spending a fortune.

Costarella has sage style advice for first home buyers who want to dress well on a meagre sum. He says:

Let's start by establishing that we must all dress for ourselves. Wear what feels right for you. Don't be dictated by what is seemingly 'in fashion'. My philosophy with my own brand, and certainly with my own wardrobe, is to build a library of great pieces. Pieces that offer wearability, versatility and longevity. It's about pieces that withstand 'trends'. Trends are a fashion marketer's dream and keep you purchasing.

And the faux pas of being caught – or Instagrammed – in an outfit twice? Costarella believes that if the piece is not worn twice a week, for a year, it's been a waste. 'If I don't get at least 100 wears out of a garment I'm frankly disappointed,' he says. 'I purchase thoughtfully and I wear my favourite pieces proudly.'

A rule I have long subscribed to, since my fashion days, is that buying black clothes disguises how much you have spent. Black is a great fashion equaliser, defusing texture, cut and fabrication. Over to you, Aurelio:

Black is always a good option for classic pieces. A woman can't go past the well-cut ubiquitous LBD [little black dress]. It lends itself to accessorising for seasonal updates. For men, a classic, tailored, well-cut black jacket is a must-have.

A note of caution: black clothing requires special attention when laundering as it fades quickly. Costarella prefers to hand-wash his black garments in cold water to minimise fading. And – may I add – hand-washing saves dollars.

Aurelio Costarella's costs-next-to-nothing closet

- At least two well-cut jackets: one black; one navy, charcoal or neutral